



2024 QUICK REVISION MATERIAL

MAHAJANAPADAS

The Janapadas were the major kingdoms of Vedic India. During that period, Aryans were the most powerful tribes and were called as 'Janas'. This gave rise to the term Janapada where Jana means 'people' and Pada means 'foot'.





LIST OF 16 MAHAJANAPADAS THAT AROSE BEFORE THE RISE OF BUDDHISM IN INDIA:

16 Mahajanapadas	Capital of the Mahajanapadas	Modern Location	Facts about 16 Mahajanapadas
Anga	Champa	Munger and Bhagalpur	- Anga Mahajanapada finds reference in the Mahabharata and Atharva Veda. - During the rule of Bimbisara, it was taken over by Magadha Empire. - It is situated in present-day Bihar and West Bengal.
Magadha	Girivraja/ Rajagriha	Gaya and Patna	- Magadha finds mention in the Atharva Veda. - It was located in present-day Bihar close to Anga, divided by river Champa. - Later, Magadha became a centre of Jainism and the first Buddhist Council was held in Rajagriha.
Kasi	Kasi	Banaras	- It was located in Varanasi. - This city got its name from rivers Varuna and Asi as cited in the Matsya Purana.
Vatsa	Kausambi	Allahabad	- Vatsa is also known as Vamsa. - Located on the banks of the Yamuna. - The capital was Kausambi - This was a central city for economic activities. - There was a prosperous trade and business prospered in the 6th century. After the rise of Buddha, the ruler Udayana made Buddhism a state religion. - Vatsa was located around the present-day Allahabad.
Kosala	Sravasti	Eastern Uttar Pradesh	- It was located in modern Awadh region of Uttar Pradesh. - Its capital was Srasvasti.
Shurasena	Mathura	Western Uttar Pradesh	This place was a centre of Krishna worship at the time of Megasthenes. Also, There was a dominant followership of Buddha.
Panchala	Ahichchatra and Kampilya	Western Uttar Pradesh	- Its capital for northern Panchala was Ahichchatra (modern Bareilly) and Kampilya (modern Farrukhabad) for its southern regions. - The famous city of Kannauj was situated in the Kingdom of Panchala. - Later the nature of governance shifted from monarchy to republic.



Kuru	Indraprastha	Meerut and Southeastern Haryana	- The area around Kurukshetra was apparently the site for Kuru Mahajanapada. - It moved to a republic form of governance.
Matsya	Viratanagara	Jaipur	- It was situated to the west of the Panchalas and south of the Kurus. - The capital was at Viratanagara. - It is situated around present-day Jaipur.
Chedi	Sothivati	Bundelkhand region	- This was cited in the Rigveda. - The capital was Sothivati. - It located in the present-day Bundelkhand region.
Avanti	Ujjaini or Mahismati	Malwa and Madhya Pradesh	- Avanti was significant in relation to the rise of Buddhism. - The capital of Avanti was located at Ujjaini or Mahismati. - It was situated around present-day Malwa and Madhya Pradesh.
Gandhara	Taxila	Rawalpindi	- The capital was at Taxila. - Gandhara is cited in the Atharva Veda. - The people were highly trained in the art of war. - It was significant for international commercial activities.
Kamboja	Poonch	Rajouri and Hajra	- The capital of Kamboja was Poonch. - It is situated in present-day Kashmir and Hindukush. - Several literary sources mention that Kamboja was a republic.
Asmaka or Assaka	Pratisthan/Paithan	Banks of Godavari	- The capital of the Mahajanapadas was located at Pratisthan or Paithan. - It was located on the banks of Godavari.
Vajji	Vaishali	Bihar	- It is the capital of Vajji was Vaishali. - The main races residing in this Mahajanapadas were Lichchhavis, Vedeans, Jnatikas and Vajji.
Malla	Kusinara	Deoria and Uttar Pradesh	- It finds a reference in Buddhist and Jain texts and in the Mahabharata. - Malla was a republic. - Their capital was kusinara situated around present-day Deoria and Uttar Pradesh.



RISE & GROWTH OF MAGADHA EMPIRE

The Magadha Empire came into existence when the four Mahajanpada- Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti engaged in the struggle for the supremacy from the 6th Century BC to 4th Century BC. Ultimately, Magadha emerged as the most powerful and prosperous kingdom in the North India. Magadha is situated in modern Bihar. Jarasandha, who was a descendant of Brihadratha, founded the empire in Magadha.

Magadha Empire – Haryanka Dynasty

There were three important kings in Haryanka Dynasty- Bimbisara, Ajatashatru and Udayin. Giriviraja was the earliest capital of Magdha and later shifted to Rajagriha.

Bimbisara (Soeniya or Sreniya)

1. He was the **first king** to have standing army and was contemporary to the **Buddha**.
2. He was the first who started matrimonial alliances to strengthen its position as a king after defeating
3. **Brahamadutta** (Anga King).
4. He had three wives: Kosaladevi (King of Kosala's daughter and the sister of Prasenjit), Chellana (daughter of the Lichchavi chief of Vaisali) and Khema (daughter of the king of Modra, Punjab).
5. Marriage relation with the different princely families gave enormous diplomatic prestige and paved the way for the expansion of Magadha western and northward.
6. Pukkusati came into his court who was the ambassador of the Gandhara ruler of Taxila.
7. He sent his personal physician Jivak (son of Salavati), to his rival Chandapradhyota Mahasena of Ujjain to cure him of jaundice.



Ajatshatru (Kunika)

1. **Son of Bimbisara and Chellana** who occupied throne by killing his father.
2. He was a contemporary of both Mahavira and Gautama Buddha and embraced Buddhism.
3. He was also instrumental in convening the First Buddhist Council at Rajagriha soon after the death of Buddha.



Udayin

1. **Son and successor of Ajatshatru**
2. Built the fort on the confluence of the Ganga and the Son river at Patliputra (now Patna)
3. He was murdered at the instigation of the king of Avanti, Palak. He was succeeded by weak successors-Anuruddha, Munda and Naga-Dasak.

MAGADHA EMPIRE : SISUNAGA DYNASTY

As per the Sri Lankan chronicles, the people of Magadha revolted during the reign of Nagadasaka and placed an amatya (minister) named Sisunaga as king.

Sisunaga

1. Was the viceroy of Kasi before becoming king of Magadha.
2. The capital was at Girivaraja which was later shifted to Vaishali.
3. He annexed Avanti and brought an end to the long rivalry between Magadha and Avanti.



Kalasoka

1. Son of Sisunaga.
2. Kalasoka shifted the capital to Pataliputra.
3. He conducted the Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali.
4. He was killed in a palace revolution that brought the Nanda dynasty to the throne.

MAGADHA EMPIRE : NANDA DYNASTY

This was the first non-Kshatriya dynasty.

Mahapadma Nanda

("First historical emperor of India.") (Chandragupta Maurya is the First Emperor of India)

1. He **murdered Kalasoka** to become the king.
2. His origins are not clear. As per the Puranas, he was the son of the last Sisunaga king from a Sudra woman. As per some Jain texts and Greek writer Curtius, he was the son of a barber and a courtesan.
3. His reign lasted for twenty-eight years from 367 BC to 338 BC.
4. He is also called "Sarva Kshatriyantaka" (destroyer of all the Kshatriyas) and "Ekkrat".
5. The empire grew under his reign. It ran from the Kuru country in the north to the Godavari Valley in the south and from Magadha in the east to Narmada on the west.



Dhana Nanda

1. He was the last Nanda ruler. He is said to be one of the sons of Mahapadma Nanda.
2. He is referred to as Agrammes or Xandrames in Greek texts.
3. Alexander invaded North-Western India during his reign, but he could not proceed towards the Gangetic plains because of his army's refusal.
4. He inherited a huge empire from his father. He possessed a standing army of 200,000 infantry, 20,000 cavalry, 3000 elephants and 2000 chariots. He became a powerful ruler because of this.
5. He became unpopular with his subjects owing to an oppressive way of extorting taxes. Also, his Sudra origins and an anti-Kshatriya policy led to a large number of enemies.
6. Finally, he was overthrown by Chandragupta Maurya along with Chanakya, which led to the foundations of the Maurya Empire in Magadha.

Reasons for the rise of Magadha

Geographical factors

- Upper and lower parts of the Gangetic valley on the mainland route between west and east India.
- The area had fertile soil and also received enough rainfall.
- Magadha was encircled by rivers on three sides, the Ganga, Son and Champa making the region impregnable to enemies.
- Both Rajgir and Pataliputra were located in strategic positions.

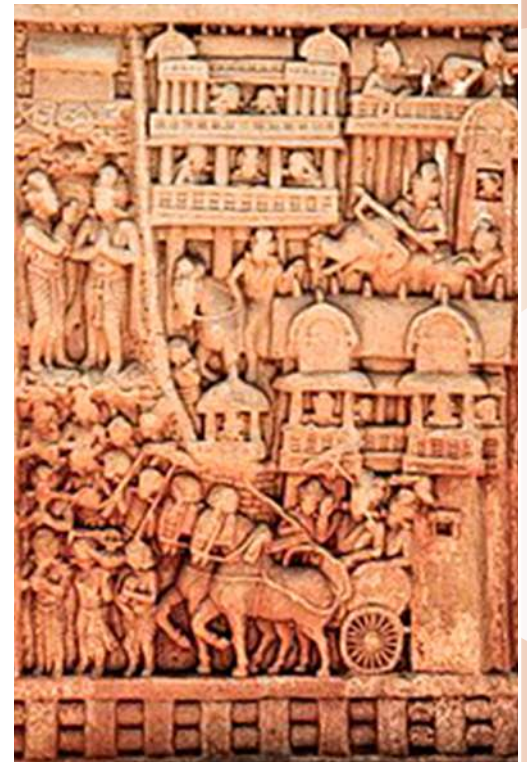
Economic factors

- **Magadha had huge copper and iron deposits.**
- Because of its location, it could easily control trade.
- Had a large population which could be used for agriculture, mining, building cities and in the army.
- The general prosperity of the people and the rulers.
- The mastery over Ganga meant economic hegemony. Ganga was important for trade in North India.
- With the **annexation of Anga by Bimbisara**, river Champa was added to the Magadha Empire. Champa was important in the trade with South-East Asia, Sri Lanka and South India.



Cultural factors

- Magadhan society had an unorthodox character which had a good mix of Aryan and non-Aryan peoples.
- The emergence of Jainism and Buddhism led to a revolution in terms of philosophy and thought.
- They enhanced liberal traditions.
- Society was not so much dominated by the Brahmanas and many kings of Magadha were 'low' in origins.



Political factors

- Magadha was lucky to have many powerful and ambitious rulers.
- They had strong standing armies.
- Availability of iron enabled them to develop advanced weaponry.
- They were also the first kings to use elephants in the army.
- The major kings also developed a good administrative system



IRANIAN AND MACEDONIAN INVASIONS

Iranian Invasion

- During the first half the sixth century B.C., there were several small principalities in the north-west India such as those of the Kambojas, Gandharas and Madras fought one another.
- The Iranian ruler Darius penetrated into north-west India in 516 B.C. and annexed Punjab, west of Indus and Sindh. This area constituted the twentieth province or satrapy of Iran.
- The Indian satrapy included Sindh, the north-west frontier and the part of Punjab that lay to the west of the Indus. It was most fertile and populous part of the empire.
- India continued to be a part of the Iranian empire till Alexander's invasion of India.

Result of the the Indo-Iranian contact That lasted for about 200 years.

- The Iranian scribes brought into India a form of writing which came to be known as the Kharosthi script. It was written from right to left like the Arabic.
- Iranian influence on the Maurya sculpture is clearly perceptible. The monuments of Ashoka's time especially the bell shaped capital, owed something to the Iranian models.
- Iranian influence may also be traced in the preamble of Ashoka's edicts as well as in certain terms used in them. For instance, for the Iranian term *dipi*, the Ashokan scribe used the term *lipi*.
- It seems that through the Iranians the Greeks came to know about the great wealth of India, which whetted their greed and eventually led to Alexander's invasion.

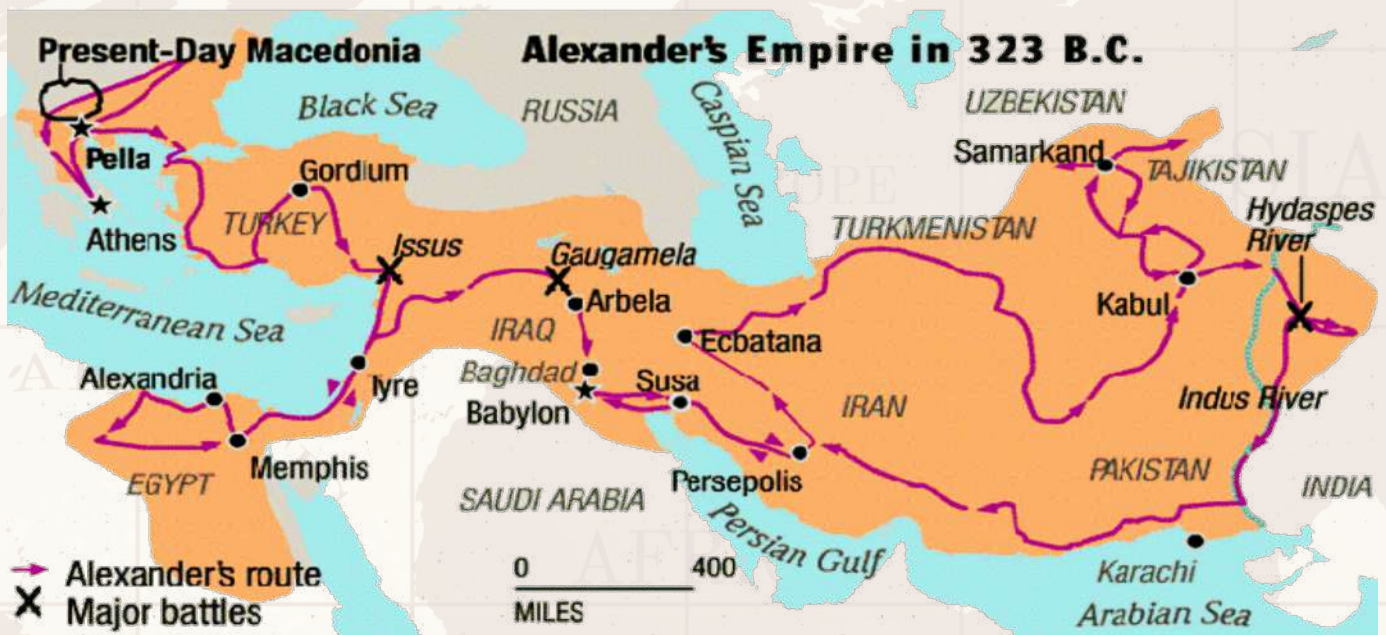
Alexander's Invasion

- Under the leadership of Alexander of Macedonia, the Greeks finally destroyed the Iranian empire.
- Alexander conquered not only Asia Minor and Iraq but also Iran.
- Herodotus, who is called father of history, and other Greek writers had painted India as, a fabulous land, which tempted Alexander to invade it.
- Alexander also possessed a strong passion for geographical inquiry and natural history.
- He had heard that the Caspian Sea continued on the eastern side of India.
- Alexander marched towards India through the Khyber pass in 326 B.C.
- Ambhi the prince of Taxila, readily submitted to the invader, augmented his army and replenished his treasure.
- Near Jhelum, Alexander met from Porus the first and the strongest resistance whose kingdom lay between the Jhelum and the Chenab. Alexander defeated Porus, he was impressed by his bravery and courage.
- Then he advanced as far as the Beas River. He wanted to move still farther eastward but his army refused to accompany him.
- The Greek soldiers had grown war-weary and diseased. The hot climate of India and ten years of continuous campaigning had made them terribly homesick.
- They had also experienced a taste of Indian fighting qualities on the bank of Indus
- As the Greek historian Arrian tells us; "In the art of war the Indians were far superior to the other nations inhabiting the area at that time."
- Especially the Greek soldiers were told of a formidable power on the Ganga.
- Obviously it was the kingdom of Magadha ruled by the Nandas who maintained an army far outnumbering that of Alexander.



- So despite the repeated appeals of Alexander to advance, the Greek soldiers did not budge an inch. Alexander lamented: "I am trying to rouse the hearts that are disloyal and crushed with craven fears".
- The king who had never known defeat at the hands of his enemies had to accept defeat from his own men. He was forced to retreat.
- He remained in India for 19 months (326-325 B.C.).
- Most conquered states were restored to their rulers who submitted to his authority.

Alexander Empire and Battle Site



Effects of Alexander's Invasion

Alexander's invasion provided the first occasion when ancient Europe came into close contact with ancient India.

- Establishment of direct contact between India and Greece in different fields: Alexander's campaign
- opened up four distinct routes by land and sea. It paved the way for Greek merchants and craftsmen.
- The invasion led to the establishment of more Greek settlements in this area. The most important of them were the city of Alexandria in the Kabul region, Boukephala on the Jhelum, and Alexandria in Sindh.
- Alexander was deeply interested in the geography of the mysterious ocean which he saw for the first time at the mouth of the Indus. Therefore he despatched his new fleet under his friend Nearchus to explore the coast and search for harbours from the mouth of the Indus to that of the Euphrates.
- Alexander's historians have left valuable geographical accounts. They also have left clearly dated records of Alexander's campaign, which enable to build Indian chronology for subsequent events on a definite basis.
- Alexander's historians also give us important information about social and economic conditions. It documents the sati system, sale of girls in market places by poor parents, and the fine breed of oxen in north-west India. The art of carpentry flourished in India and carpenters built chariots, boats and ships.
- His invasion paved the way for the expansion of the Maurya Empire in that area. According to tradition, Chandragupta Maurya had seen the working of the army Alexander and acquired some knowledge which helped him in destroying the Nandas.

Mauryan Age

The last of the Nanda rulers, Dhana Nanda was highly unpopular due to his oppressive tax regime. Also, post-Alexander's invasion of North-Western India, that region faced a lot of unrest from foreign powers. Chandragupta, with the help of an intelligent and politically astute Brahmin, Kautilya usurped the throne by defeating Dhana Nanda in 321 BC.

Chandragupta

Chandragupta liberated north western India from Seleucus Nicator, who ruled area west of the Indus. He entered into a treaty with Seleucus Nicator in which Chandragupta acquired Baluchistan, eastern Afghanistan and the region to the west of Indus. In return, Seleucus Nicator got 500 elephants. Chandragupta thus built up a vast empire covering the whole of the subcontinent.



Timeline of important Maurya Rule

Rule	Span of Rule
Chandragupta Maurya	321-297 BC
Bindusara	297-272 BC
Asoka	272-232 BC



Ashoka

He is greatest of the Mauryan rulers. According to the Buddhist tradition, he killed his 99 brothers to get the throne.



Bindusara

Son of Chandragupta. Also called Amitraghata (Slayer of foes) or Amitrochates in Greek sources. Deimachus was a Greek ambassador at his court. He had appointed his son, Ashoka as the governor of Ujjain. Bindusara is believed to have extended the Mauryan Empire to Mysore as well.



Ashokan Inscriptions

- Inscription is bases of the reconstructed history of Ashoka which are classified into: Major Rock Edicts; Minor Rock Edicts; Separate Rock Edicts; Major Pillar Edicts; and Minor pillar Edicts
- These inscriptions are found in India, Nepal, Pakistan and Afghanistan. In these inscriptions, Ashok refers to himself as "Devanampiya piyadasi" which means "dear to God".
- The name of Ashoka occurs only in copies of a Minor Rock Edicts I found at the three places in Karnataka and at one in Madhya Pradesh.
- They appeared in Aramaic language and Kharoshthi Script in north-western part of the sub-continent. In Afghanistan, they were written in both Aramaic and Greek Scripts and languages.

Impact of Kalinga war

Bindusara

Kalinga war was one of the major war fought by Ashoka. Loss caused during war caused Ashoka much grief and remorse. So he abandoned the policy of physical conquest with cultural conquest i.e. bherighosha was replaced by dhammaghosha. Ashoka converted to Buddhism and missionaries were sent to Sri Lanka, Burma and other countries to promote Buddhism.



Significance of the Mauryan rule

1. State Control

- Kautilya advises the king to promulgate dharma when the social order based on the varnas and ashramas (stages in life) collapses. He calls the king dharmapravartaka or promulgator of the social order. Ashoka promulgated dharma and appointed officials to inculcate and enforce its essentials throughout India.
- The administrative mechanism was backed by an elaborate system of espionage. Various types of spies collected intelligence about foreign enemies and kept an eye on numerous officers.
- Important functionaries were called tirtha. It appears that most functionaries were paid in cash, the highest among whom, the minister (mantrin), high priest (purohita), commander-in-chief (senapati) and crown prince (yuvaraja), were paid generously.

2. Economic Regulations

- The state appointed twenty-seven superintendents (adhyakshas), principally to regulate its economic activities. They controlled and regulated agriculture, trade and commerce, weights and measures, crafts such as weaving and spinning, mining, and the like. The state also provided irrigation facilities and regulated water supply for the benefit of agriculturists.
- According to the Arthashastra of Kautilya, a striking social development of the Maurya period was the employment of slaves in agricultural operations. royal control was exercised over a very large area, at least in the core of the empire.
- The Ashokan inscriptions appear on important highways. The stone pillars were made in Chunar near Varanasi from where they were transported to north and south India.
- Pataliputra was the chief centre of royal power, but Tosali, Suvarnagiri, Ujjain, and Taxila were seats of provincial power. Each of them was governed by a governor called kumara or prince, and thus every governor hailed from the royal family.
- The Maurya period constitutes a landmark in the system of taxation in ancient India. Kautilya names many taxes which were collected from peasants, artisans, and traders. This required a strong and efficient machinery for assessment, collection, and storage.
- The Mauryas attached greater importance to assessment than to storage and deposit. The samaharta was the highest officer in charge of assessment and collection, and the sannidhata was the chief custodian of the state treasury and storehouse. The assessor-cum-collector was far more important than the chief treasurer.
- It seems that the punch-marked silver coins, which carry the symbols of the peacock and crescented hill, formed the imperial currency of the Mauryas.



3. Art and Architecture

- Fragments of stone pillars and stumps, indicating the existence of an 84-pillared hall, have been discovered at Kumrahar on the outskirts of modern Patna. Each pillar is made of a single piece of buff-coloured sandstone. Only their capitals, which are beautiful pieces of sculpture in the form of lions or bulls, are joined to the pillars on the top. The erection of the polished pillars throughout India shows the spread of the technical knowledge involved in the art of polishing them. The earliest examples are the Barabar caves at a distance of 30 km from Gaya.
- In the central phase of the Northern Black Polished Ware around 300 BC, the central Gangetic plains became the centre of terracotta art.
- The stone statue of Yakshini in the form of a beautiful woman found in Didarganj (Patna) is noted for its Maurya polish.

4. Spread of Material Culture

- This period evidences socketed axes, hoes, spades, sickles, and ploughshares. Besides these iron implements, the spoked wheel also began to be used.
- In the end of the Maurya period burnt bricks were used for the first time in north-eastern India. Maurya constructions made of burnt bricks have been found in Bihar and UP.
- Ring wells, which were first constructed under the Mauryas in the Gangetic plains spread beyond the heart of the empire.
- The art of making steel may have spread through Maurya contacts across some other parts of India. Steel objects relating to about 200 BC or an earlier date have been found in the mid-Gangetic plains. The spread of steel may have led to jungle clearance and the use of better methods of cultivation in Kalinga, and could have created the conditions for the rise of the Cheti kingdom in that region

Sources of Mauryas Age

1. Buddhist Texts: Jatakas, Divyavadana and Ashokavadana
2. Srilankan Text, Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa
3. Puranas
4. Kautilya's Arthashastra (Politico-economy or Statecraft)
5. Indica (Megasthenes)
6. Vishakhadatta's Mudrarakshasa (Account of how Nandas overthrown by Chandragupta Mauryas in Sanskrit)
7. Somadeva's Kathasaritasagara, Kshemendra's Brihadkatha Manjari and Kalhana's Rajtrangaini
8. Ashokan Inscriptions and edicts.

Causes of the fall of the Maurya Empire

- **Brahmanical Reaction:** The tolerance policy of Ashoka developed some kind of antipathy because animals and birds sacrifice, and women derided superfluous ritual performed affected the income of the brahmanas. New Kingdoms like Shungas, Kanvas etc ruled by Brahamanas arose to ruined the empire.
- **Financial Crisis:** The enormous expenditure on the army and payment to bureaucracy created a financial crisis for the empire.
- **Oppressive Rule** in the province was an important cause of the break-up of the empire.
- **Spread of New material Knowledge in the Outlying Areas:** Mauraya rule owned its expansion to certain basic material advantages and this causes the rise of new kingdoms like Shungas, Kanvas, Chetis and Satvahanas.
- **Neglected the North-West Frontier and the Great Wall of China:** Maurya ruler could not pay attention to the passage on the north-west frontier. This is the only reason, Scythians made a push towards India they forced the Parthians, the Shakas and the Greeks to move towards India. The Chinese ruler Shih Huang Ti (247-210 BC) constructed wall i.e. Great Wall of China to shield his empire from alien attack especially from Scythians.

CENTRAL ASIAN CONTACT AND THEIR RESULTS

The Indo-Greeks

1. A series of invasions took place from about 200 BCE. The first to cross the Hindukush were the Greeks, who ruled Bactria, lying south of the Oxus river in the area covered by north Afghanistan.



Causes of invasion

- Weakness of the Seleucid empire, which had been established in Bactria and the adjoining areas of Iran called Parthia.
- Due to the growing pressure from the Scythian tribes, the later Greek rulers were unable to hold their power in this area.
- The construction of the Chinese wall prevented the Scythians from entering China. So, their attention turned towards Greeks and Parthians. Pushed by the Scythian tribes, the Bactrian Greeks were forced to invade India.
- The successors of Ashoka were too weak to thwart the attack.

In the beginning of the 2nd century BCE, the Indo-Greeks/Bactrian Greeks were the first to invade India. They occupied a large part of north-western India, much larger than that conquered by Alexander. It is believed that they pushed forward to as far as Ayodhya and Pataliputra. However, the Greeks failed to establish a united rule in India. Two Greek dynasties ruled north-western India on parallel lines at the same time. The Indo-Bactrian rule is important in the history of India because of the large number of coins issued by the Greek kings. The Indo-Greeks were the first rulers in India to issue coins which can be definitely attributed to the kings. It is rather interesting to note that out of the forty-two Indo-Greek kings, as many as 34 are known only through their coins.

Demetrius (King of Bactria)

- Invaded India around 190 BCE and probably also came into conflict with Pushyamitra Sunga, founder of the Sunga dynasty.
- Conquered a large part of north-western India and also extended Bactrian rule to the south of the Hindukush.



Menander/Milinda/Minedra (165 BCE- 145 BCE)

- The most celebrated Indo-Greek ruler who stabilized Indo-Greek power and also extended his empire's frontiers in India.
- Also included southern Afghanistan and Gandhara, the region west of the Indus river.
- Had his capital at Sakala (modern Sialkot, Punjab, Pakistan).
- It is believed that he invaded Ganga-Yamuna doab but had failed to retain it for long.
- He was converted to Buddhism by Nagasena, (also known as Nagarjuna). Menander has been identified with the king Milinda mentioned in the famous Buddhist text Milindapanho (Question of Milinda), which contains philosophical questions that Milinda asked Nagasena. The text claims that impressed by the answers, the king accepted Buddhism as his religion.
- He is also identified with king Minedra mentioned in a fragmented Kharosthi inscription found on a casket at Bajaur (presently in Pakistan) which refers to the enshrining of relics of the Buddha, probably in a stupa, during his reign.

hermaius

- He was the last ruler of this dynasty and was defeated by the Parthians around the last quarter of the 2nd century BCE, which led to the end of Greek rule in Bactria and the area to the south of the Hindukush.
- However, the Indo-Greek rule continued in north-western India for some more time.
- This north-western Gandhara region was also lost to Parthians and Shakas in due course of time.
- Later, in the late 1st century BCE or the early 1st century CE, the remaining part of the territory, i.e, the area to the east of the Jhelum also ceded to the Kshatrapa ruler Rajuvula.

Impact of the Indo-Greek Rule

- The Indo-Greeks were the first rulers in India to issue coins (gold, silver, copper and nickel). The coins of the Shakas, Parthians and the Kshatrapas followed the basic features of the Indo-Greek coinage, including the bilingual and bi-script legends. These coins provide important information about the religious sects and cults of that era (especially Shaiva and Bhagavata sects).
- The Indo-Greeks introduced Gandhara art in the north-west frontier of India, which was the outcome of the intermingling and influence of both Indian and central Asian contacts.
- The Indo-Greeks also introduced the practice of military governorship and the Governors were called strategos/satrapas.
- The Hellenistic Greeks are well known for their monumental buildings and finely crafted objects. Excavation of the cities reveals a great talent in urban planning.

Shakas/Scythians

Shakas is the Indian term for the people called the Scythians, who originally belonged to Central Asia. There were five branches of the Shakas with their seats of power in different parts of India and Afghanistan.

1. One branch of the Shakas settled in Afghanistan. Prominent rulers of this branch were Vonones and Spalirises.
2. The second branch settled in Punjab with Taxila as their capital. Maues was a prominent ruler.
3. The third branch settled in Mathura, where they ruled for about two centuries. Azilises was a prominent ruler.
4. The fourth branch established its hold over western India, where they continued to rule till the 4th century CE. They ruled for the maximum period owing to a flourishing economy based on the sea-borne trade in Gujarat and also issued a large number of silver coins. One of the famous Shaka rulers was Rudradaman 1 (CE 130-150). He ruled over Sindh, Kutch and Gujarat and also recovered from the Satavahanas, Kokan, the Narmada valley, Malwa and Kathiawar. He is famous in history because of the repairs he undertook to improve the Sudarsana lake in the semi-arid zone of Kathiawar. He was a great lover of Sanskrit and issued the first-ever long inscription in chaste Sanskrit. All the earlier longer inscriptions were composed in Prakrit.

5. The fifth branch of the Shakas established its power in the upper Deccan. The Shakas did not meet effective resistance from the rulers and the masses of India. The king of Ujjain (around 58 BCE), effectively fought and succeeded in throwing the Shakas out. He called himself Vikramaditya and an era called Vikram-Samvat is reckoned from the event of his victory over the Shakas in 58 BCE. From this time onwards, Vikramaditya became a coveted title and whoever achieved anything great adopted this title, as the Roman emperors adopted the title Caesar in order to emphasize their great power.

Parthians

In the mid 1st century CE, the Shakas' domination in northwest India was followed by that of the **Parthians**. In many ancient Sanskrit texts, they are mentioned together as the Shaka-Pahlava. Originally the Parthians lived in Iran, from where they moved to India and in comparison with the Greeks and the Shakas they occupied a small portion of north-western India in the 1st century. The most famous Parthian king was Gondophernes (mentioned in an inscription dated 45 CE found at Takht-i-Bahi, recovered from Mardan near Peshawar) in whose reign Saint Thomas came to India to propagate Christianity. In due course of time, the Parthians, like the Shakas, became assimilated into Indian society and became an integral part of it. The Kushanas ultimately ousted the successors of Gondophernes from north-west India.

Kushanas

The Parthians were followed by the Kushanas who were also called Yue-Chis (moon tribe) or Tocharians. The Kushanas were one of the five clans into which the Yue-Chis tribe was divided. They were nomadic tribal people who were originally from the steppes of North Central Asia, in the neighbourhood of China. They first occupied Bactria or north Afghanistan where they displaced the Shakas, and gradually moved to the Kabul valley and seized

Gandhara by crossing the Hindu Kush, replacing the rule of the Greeks and the Parthians in these areas. Finally, they set up their authority over the lower Indus basin and the greater part of the Gangetic basin. Their empire extended from the Oxus to the Ganga, from Khorasan in Central Asia to Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh. A good part of Central Asia, a portion of Iran, a portion of Afghanistan, the whole of Pakistan and almost the whole of northern India were brought under one rule by the Kushanas.



The Kushana dynasty was founded by a house of chiefs called Kadphises.

Kujula Kadphises 1 (15 CE – 64 CE)

- He laid the foundation of a unified Kushana empire by amalgamating the five clans of the Yue-Chi tribe.
- He minted the coins in copper and is believed to have imitated the Roman 'aurei' type coins to facilitate trade.
- His coins have been found south of the Hindukush.
- His coins give an idea about his association with Buddhism.
- He adopted the epithet 'Dharmathida' and 'Sachadharmathida'.

Vima Kadphises 2 (64 CE – 78 CE)

- He was the son of Kadphises 1.
- He conquered Gandhara from the Parthians and extended the kingdom to the east of the Indus till Mathura region.
- He issued a large number of gold coins.
- He was a firm devotee of Lord Shiva and proclaimed himself as 'Mahishvara' on his coins.

Kanishka (78 CE – 105 CE)

- He is the most famous Kushan ruler. During his reign, the kingdom expanded from Central Asia to Afghanistan and from northwestern India to further east into the Ganga valley and also southwards into the Malwa region. The empire also included Varanasi, Kaushambi and Shravasti in Uttar Pradesh and Sanchi in Madhya Pradesh. The centre of this huge empire was Bactria, as is evident in the use of the Bactrian language in Kanishka's coins and inscriptions.
- The valuable information about Kanishka is provided by the famous **Rabatak inscription (Afghanistan)**.
- Adopted the title of '**Devputra**' and on some coins has been shown wearing a peaked helmet.
- His empire had two capitals – the first one was at Purushapura (Peshawar) where Kanishka erected a monastery and a huge stupa to house the Buddha's relics. The second one was at Mathura in India.
- Kanishka is famous for two reasons: First, he started an era in 78 CE which is now known as the Shaka era and is used by the government of India for its calendar. Secondly, Kanishka extended his whole-hearted patronage to Buddhism. He also convened the fourth Buddhist council to discuss matters relating to Buddhist theology and doctrine. It was held at Kundalavana monastery near Srinagar (Kashmir) under the presidency of Vasumitra. It was in this council that Buddhism was split into two schools – the Hinayana and the Mahayana.
- Kanishka patronized Buddhist scholars of that era like Vasumitra (authored Mahavibhasa), Ashvagosha (wrote the hagiographic Buddhacharita), Charaka (The father of Ayurveda), Nagarjuna (a great advocate of the Mahayana doctrine and propounded the Madhyamaka which focuses on emptiness or Sunyata).
- Kanishka embraced Buddhism in the early part of his reign. However, his coins exhibit the images of not only Buddha but also of Greek and Hindu Gods. It reflects Kanishka's tolerance towards other religions.
- Kanishka also patronised the Gandhara and the Mathura schools of sculpture. At Mathura, a headless statue of Kanishka depicting him as a warrior has been found.



Vasudeva (the last Kushana emperor)

- The successors of Kanishka were Vasishka, Huvishka, Kanishka II (who adopted the title of 'Kaiser') and Vasudeva – the last important Kushana ruler. The Kushana empire was very much reduced in his rule. Around the mid 2nd century he took the title 'Shaono Shao Vasudevo Koshano', which reflects that by this time the Kushanas were totally Indianised.
- Kushana power gradually declined from the early third century CE. The Kushana empire in Afghanistan and in the area west of the Indus was supplanted by the Sassanian power (of Iran) in the mid-third century CE. But Kushan principalities continued to exist in India for about a century. Some remnants of the Kushanas lingered on in the Kabul valley, Kapisa, Bactria, Khorezm and Sogdian (identical with Bukhara and Samarkand) in the third-fourth century CE.

Impact of Central Asian Contacts

The Central Asian influence was felt in almost all spheres and aspects of social life.

1. Pottery and Architecture

- The typical pottery of this age (Shaka-Kushana) was red ware, both in plain and polished form with medium to fine fabric.
- The distinctive pots being sprinklers and spouted channels.
- The age was marked by the construction of brick walls. The use of burnt bricks for flooring and tiles for both roofing and flooring was evident.



2. Trade and Agriculture

- The Shaka-Kushana phase saw the establishment of direct contact between India and Central Asia which helped to develop trade between the two.
- India imported a good deal of gold from the Altai mountains of Central Asia. Gold also may have been received in India through trade with the Roman empire.
- The silk route which started from China and crossed through the empire in Central Asia and Afghanistan to Iran and Western Asia was controlled by the Kushanas.
- This route was a source of great income to the Kushanas and they built a large prosperous empire because of the tolls levied from the traders.
- Although the Indo-Greeks introduced gold coins in India, the Kushans were the first rulers in India to issue gold coins on a large scale.
- The Kushans also promoted agriculture. The archaeological traces of irrigation facilities have been discovered in parts of Afghanistan, Pakistan and Western Central Asia.

3. Trade and Agriculture

- The Shakas and the Kushanas introduced better cavalry and popularised the use of riding horses on a large scale.
- The use of reins, saddles and toe-stirrup made of rope was common in this phase.
- They also introduced tunic, turban, trousers, heavy long coats and long boots which facilitated victories in war.

4. Polity

- The Shakas-Kushanas propagated the idea of the divine origin of kinship.
- The Kushan kings were called sons of god.
- The Kushanas introduced the “satrap system” of government wherein the empire was divided into numerous satrapies and each satrapy was placed under the rule of a Satrap.
- The Indo-Greeks introduced the practice of military governorship wherein they appointed their governors called strategos. Military governors were necessary to maintain the power of foreign rulers over the conquered people.

5. Indian Society

- The Shakas and the Kushanas added new elements to Indian culture and enriched it immensely.
- They settled in India for good and completely identified themselves with its culture.
- Since they did not have their own script, language or religion, they adopted these elements of culture from India. They became completely Indianised in course of time.
- As most of them came as conquerors they were absorbed in Indian society as a warrior class, Kshatriyas.
- The lawgiver Manu stated that the Shakas and the Parthians were the Kshatriyas who had fallen from their status and were thus considered as second-class Kshatriyas.
- In no other period of ancient history were foreigners assimilated into Indian society on such a large scale as they were in the post-Maurya period.

6. Religion

- Some of the foreign rulers converted to Vaishnavism (worshipped Vishnu – the god of protection and preservation). The Greek ambassador Hellodorus set up a pillar in honour of Vishnu near Vidisha in Madhya Pradesh.
- A few others adopted Buddhism, as in the case of the Greek ruler Menander who became a Buddhist.
- The Kushana rulers worshipped both Shiva and the Buddha as is evident from the images of these two gods on the Kushana coins.
- Buddhism in its original form was too puritanical and abstract for foreigners. They did not appreciate the philosophical doctrines of Buddhism, emphasized by the existing Buddhist schools. So, there developed a new form of Buddhism called the Mahayana or the Great Wheel, in which the image of the Buddha began to be worshipped. Kanishka was a great patron of the Mahayana form of Buddhism who not only organised the fourth Buddhist council at Srinagar but also set up many stupas to perpetuate the memory of the Buddha. This sect opened its doors for all sections of people. Those who did not follow this sect (newly found) came to be known as the followers of the Hinayana sect or the Small Wheel.

7. Art and Literature

- The construction of stupas and development of regional schools of sculpture are the two main features concerning art and architecture of this period.
- Stupas – A stupa is a large hemispherical dome having a central chamber in which relics of the Buddha or some Buddhist monk are kept in a small casket. The base is surrounded by a path for clockwise circumambulation (pradakshina), enclosed by wooden railings which were later made in stone. The three main stupas of this period are at Bharhut (dates to the middle of the second century, its railings are made of red stone), Sanchi (three big stupas were constructed at Sanchi, the biggest one was originally made by Ashoka, which was enlarged to twice its size in the second century), and Amravati and Nagarjungkonda (Andhra Pradesh).
- Schools of Sculpture – The Central Asian rulers became enthusiastic patrons of Indian art and culture and showed great zeal in establishing new schools of art. The Kushana empire brought together masons and other artisans trained in different schools and countries. Indian craftsmen came into contact with the Greeks and the Romans, especially in the north-western frontier of India in Gandhara. The three main schools of sculptural art which developed in this period were – Gandhara school of Art, Mathura school of Art and Amravati school of Art.

Gandhara School



Mathura School



Amravati School



Basis	Gandhara School	Mathura School	Amaravati School
External influence	Heavy influence of Greek or Hellenistic sculpture, so it is also known as Indo-Greek art .	It was developed indigenously and not influenced by external cultures.	It was developed indigenously and not influenced by external cultures.
Ingredient used	Early Gandhara School used bluish-grey sandstone while the latter period saw the use of mud and stucco .	The sculptures of Mathura School were made using spotted red sandstone .	The sculptures of Amaravathi School were made using white marbles.
Religious influence	Mainly Buddhist imagery , influenced by the Greco-Roman pantheon .	Influence of all three religions of the time, i.e. Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism.	Mainly Buddhist influence.
Patronage	Patronised by Kushana rulers	Patronised by Kushana rulers .	Patronised by Satvahana rulers .
Area of development	Developed in the North West Frontier, in modern day area of Kandhara.	Developed in and around Mathura, Sonkh and Kankalitila. Kankalitila was famous for Jain sculptures.	Developed in the Krishna-Godavari lower valley, in and around Amaravati and Nagaarjunakonda.
Features of Budha sculpture	The Buddha is shown in a spiritual state , with wavy hair. He wears fewer ornaments and seated in the position of a yogi . The eyes are half-closed as in meditation. A protuberance is shown on the head signifying the omniscience of Buddha.	Buddha is shown in delighted mood with a smiling face. The body is muscular, wearing tight dress. The face and head are shaven. Buddha is seated in padmasana with different mudras and his face reflects grace. A similar protuberance is shown on the head.	Since the sculptures are generally part of a narrative art, there is less emphasis on the individual features of Buddha. The sculptures generally depict life stories of Buddha and the Jataka tales. i.e. previous lives of Buddha in both human and animal form.

Examples



8. Science and technology

- Indian astronomy and astrology profited from contact with the Greeks.

AGE OF THE SATAVAHANAS

1. Political History

- In Deccan and in central India, the Satavahanas succeeded the Mauryas although after a gap of about 100 years. The Satavahanas are considered to be identical with the Andhras who are mentioned in the Puranas. The Puranas speak only of the Andhra rule and not of the Satavahana rule.
- The earliest inscriptions of the Satavahanas belong to the first century B.C., when they defeated the Kanvas and established their power in parts of central India and gradually the extended their power over Karnataka and Andhra,
- **Gautamiputra Satakarni** (A.D. 106-130) called himself the only brahmana. He defeated the Shakas and destroyed many Kshatriya rulers.
- The coins and inscriptions of Gautamiputra's immediate successor Vashishthiputra Pulumayi (A.D. 130-154) are found in Andhra. He set up his capital at Paithan on the Godavari in Aurangabad district.
- Rudradaman I (A.D. 130-150), the Shaka ruler of Saurashtra (Kathiawar), defeated the Satavahanas twice, but did not destroy them on account of matrimonial relations. Yajna Sri Satakarni recovered north Konkan and Malwa from the Shaka rulers. He was a lover of trade and navigation. His coins have been found not only in Andhra but also in Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat. His love for navigation and overseas trade is shown by the representation of a ship on his coins.



2. Aspects of Material Culture

- The material culture of the Deccan under the Satavahanas was a fusion of local elements and northern ingredients. The megalith builders of the Deccan were fairly acquainted with the use of iron and agriculture. At a site Karimnagar district even a blacksmith shop has been discovered.
- The Satavahanas may have exploited the iron workings as early as the megalithic phases have been found. Evidence of ancient gold workings has been found in the Kolar fields in the pre-Christian centuries and later.
- The Satavahanas may have used gold as bullion, for they did not issue gold coins as the Kushans did. They issued mostly coins of lead. They also issued potin, copper and bronze money.
- In foreign accounts, Andhra is considered to be famous for its cotton products. A good portion of the Deccan developed a very advanced rural economy.
- According to Pliny, the Andhra Kingdom maintained an army of 1,00,000 infantry, 2000 cavalry and 1000 elephants. This presupposes a large rural population, and apparently the peasants produced enough to support this military strength.
- Pliny informs us that the Andhra country in the eastern Deccan included 30 walled towns, besides numerous villages. Increasing trade is indicated by numerous Roman and Satavahana coins.

3. Social Organization

- The Satavahanas originally seem to have been a tribe of the **Deccan**. But they were brahmanized and their most famous king Gautamiputra Satakarni claims to have established the four-fold vama system which had fallen into disorder. He boasts that he put an end to the intermixture between the people of different social orders.
- The Satavahanas were also the first rulers to make land grants to the brahmanas, although we have more instances of grants being made to Buddhist monks. The Satavahana rulers called themselves brahmanas. Gautamiputra boasts that he was the true brahmana.



- Increasing craft and commerce in this period brought many merchants and artisans to the forefront. Both artisans and merchants made generous donations to the Buddhist cause. Among the artisans the gandhikas or the perfumers are repeatedly mentioned as donors. At a later stage the term gandhika became so general as to connote all kinds of shopkeepers. The modern title Gandhi is derived from this ancient term.
- Satavahanas show traces of a matrilineal social structure. It was customary for their king to be, named after his mother. Such names as Gautamiputra and Vashishthiputra indicate that in their society mother enjoyed a great deal of importance.
- The Satavahanas retained some of the administrative units found in Ashokan times. Their district was called Ahara, as it was known in the time of Ashoka. Their officials were known as Amatyas and Mahamatras. There were certain military and feudal traits in the administration of the Satavahanas.
- The administration in the rural areas was placed in the hands of gaulmika, who was the head of a military regiment consisting of 9 chariots, 9 elephants, 25 horses and 45 foot-soldiers.
- The military character of the Satavahana rule is also evident from the common use of such terms as Kataka and Skandhavaras in their inscriptions. These were military camps and settlements which served as administrative centers so long as the king was there.
- The Satavahanas started the practice of granting tax-free villages to brahmanas and Buddhist monks. These areas therefore became small independent islands within the Satavahana kingdom.
- The Satavahana kingdom had three grades of feudatories. The highest grade was formed by the king who was called raja and who had the right to strike coins. The second grade was formed by the mahabhoja, and the third grade by the senapati. It seems that these feudatories and landed beneficiaries enjoyed some authority in their respective localities.

4. Religion

- The Satavahana rulers were brahmanas, and they represented the march of triumphant brahmanism. Kings and Queens performed the Vedic sacrifices. They also worshipped a large number of Vaishnava gods.
- However, the Satavahana rulers promoted Buddhism by granting land to the monks. In their kingdom the Mahayana form of Buddhism commanded considerable following especially in the artisan class. Nagarjunakonda and Amaravati in Andhra Pradesh became important seats of Buddhist culture under the Satavahanas and more so under their successors, the Ikshvakus. Buddhism flourished in the Nasik and Junar areas in the western Deccan in Maharashtra, where it seems to have been supported by the traders.

5. Architecture

- In the Satavahana phase many chaityas (sacred shrines) and monasteries were cut out of the solid rock in the north-western Deccan or Maharashtra with great skill and patience.
- The two common religious constructions were the Buddhist temple which was called chaitya and the monastery which was called vihara. The chaitya was a large hall with a number of columns, and the vihara consisted of a central hall. The most famous chaitya is that of Karle in the western Deccan.
- The viharas or monasteries were excavated near the chaityas for the residence of monks in the rainy season.
- Rock-cut architecture is also to be found in Andhra in the Krishna-Godavari region but the region is really famous for independent Buddhist structures, mostly in the form of stupas. The most famous of them are Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda. The stupa was a large round structure erected over some relic of the Buddha. The Amaravati stupa began in about 200 B.C. but was completely reconstructed in the second half of the second century A.D.

6. Language

- The official language of the Satavahanas was **Prakrit**. All inscriptions were composed in this language and written in the Brahmi script, as was the case in Ashokan times.
- Some satavahana king may have composed prakrit text called gathasaptasati is attributed to a Satavahana king called **Hala**.

HISTORY OF THE DEEP SOUTH

The Megalithic Background

Megalith graves were encircled by big pieces of stones. They also contained pottery and iron objects buried with the corpse. They are found in the upland regions of Peninsula with concentration in **Eastern Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu**.

State formation and rise of civilization

- The megalithic people started to reclaim the fertile deltaic lands. The route to the south is called as **Dakshinapatha** which became **economically important**.
- Megasthenes knew about Pandyas while Ashokan inscriptions mention about Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satyaputras.
- Flourishing trade with Roman empire led to the formation of these three states i.e., **Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas**.

Sangam Period

Sangam period is the period in the history of ancient Tamil Nadu spanning from c. 3rd century BC to c. 3rd century AD. It is named after the famous Sangam academies of poets and scholars centred in the city of Madurai.



**Great Temple:
Thanjavur**



Three Early Kingdoms

Kingdom	Capital	Port	Emblem	Famous Ruler
Cheras	Vanji Modern Kerala	Muzuri, Tondi	Bow	Senguttuvan
Cholas	Uraiyur, Puhar	Kaveripattanam/ Puhar. they had an efficient Navy	Tiger	Karikalan
Pandyas	Madurai	Korkai for Peral Fishing	Fish	Neduncheliyan

Cheras

- They had Palmyra flowers as their Garland.
- Pugalur inscriptions mention of three generations of Cheras.
- Senguttuvan introduced Pattni cult or Worship of Kannagi as ideal wife.



Cholas

- Karikalan built Kallanai (Check dam) against River Kaveri.



Pandyas

- Maduraikkanji written by Mangudi Maruthanar describes the socio-economic conditions of the Pandyas.
- Invasion by Kalbharas led to their decline.
- These kingdoms had a profitable trade with the Roman empire. They produced Pepper, Ivory, Pearls, Precious stones, Muslin, Silk, Cotton etc. which led to prosperity in their region.



Rise of social classes

Enadi – captains of the army

Vellalas – Rich peasants

Arasar – ruling class

Kadaiyiar – the lowest class

Pariyars – agricultural labourers

Four castes mentioned in Tolkappiyam

Arasar – Ruling class

Anthanar – Brahmanas

Vanigar – People involved in Trade and Commerce

Vellalar – Labourers

Sangam administration

- Avai – the imperial court
- Kodimaram – tutelary tree of every ruler
- Panchmahasabha
- Amaichar – ministers
- Senatipathiar – Army chief
- Otrar – Spy
- Thoodar – Envoy
- Purohitar – Priest

Kingdom's division

- Mandalam/Nadu – Province
- Ur – town
- Perur – Big village
- Sitrur – Small village



Five-fold division of land

Land	Type of land	Chief deity	Chief occupation
Kurunji	Hilly tracts	Murugan	Hunting and honey collection
Mullai	Pastoral	Mayon	Cattle rearing and dealing with dairy products
Marudham	Agricultural	Indira	Agricultural
Neidhal	Coastal	Varunan	Fishing and salt manufacturing
Palai	Desert	Korravai	Robbery

Sangams

Sangam	Place	Chairman	Surviving texts
1 st	Then-Madurai	Agasthiyar	Nil
2 nd	Kapadapuram	Agasthiyar and Tolkappiyar	Tolkappiyam
3 rd	Madurai	Founder - Mudathirumaran Nakkirar	Ettutogai, Pattu Pattu (10 idylls)

Tamil language and Sangam literature

- Narrative** – Ettutogai and Pattupattu which are called **Melkankakku** – 18 Major works. They are divided into **Agam** (love) and **Puram** (Valour)
- Didactive** – Pathinenkilkanakku – 18 minor works. They deal with Ethics and Morals.
- Thirukkural** – Written by Thiruvalluvar is a treatise covering various aspects of life.
- Tolkappiyam** by Tolkappiyar is the earliest of Tamil literature. It is a work on Tamil Grammar but also provides information on Political and Social conditions of Sangam period

Epics

- Silapadhikaram by Elango Adigal
- Manimegalai by Sitthalai Sathanar
- Valayapathi
- Kundalagesi
- Sivaga Sinthamani

